

Checklist:

Changing Jobs

1. Exploring new opportunities

- ☐ Decide whether you are actively looking, passively open, or happy but curious.
- ☐ Clarify what would make a new opportunity worth pursuing.
- ☐ Update your LinkedIn/profile if actively looking.
- ☐ Respond selectively to inbound recruiter messages.
- ☐ Use conversations to understand your market value.
- ☐ Compare opportunities against compensation, role, growth, team, mission, flexibility, and long-term upside.

2. Promotion vs switching jobs

- ☐ Assess whether you are already performing at the next level.
- ☐ Understand whether your company's promotion process is slow or backward-looking.
- ☐ Compare internal promotion odds with external offers.
- ☐ Consider whether switching jobs may reset your trust, context, and influence.
- ☐ For senior roles, weigh the value of tenure and internal relationships.
- ☐ Avoid optimizing only for title or compensation; think about 5–10 year career impact.

3. Preparing for tech interviews

- ☐ Ask the recruiter what the interview process looks like.
- ☐ Confirm whether there will be coding, system design, behavioral, domain deep-dive, or bar-raiser interviews.
- ☐ Prepare a resume that clearly highlights relevant experience and measurable impact.
- ☐ Practice coding and debugging interviews.
- ☐ Prepare for system design or architecture interviews.

- ☐ Prepare behavioral stories about motivation, conflict, hard situations, and values.
- ☐ Ask clarifying questions during technical interviews.
- ☐ For take-home tasks, confirm time expectations and whether feedback will be provided.
- ☐ For staff+ roles, prepare for deeper domain, product, director-level, or second system-design rounds.

4. Handling down-leveling

- ☐ Compare both title and compensation, not just one.
- ☐ Ask what the offered level means and what the next level requires.
- ☐ Understand whether the company has higher expectations than your current company.
- ☐ Ask whether the hiring committee can reconsider your level if you disagree.
- ☐ Decide whether the lower title is acceptable given pay, growth, company, and opportunity.
- ☐ Reject the offer if the level feels significantly misaligned with your career goals.

5. Handling up-leveling

- ☐ Confirm that the higher level comes with clear expectations.
- ☐ Ask what success looks like at that level.
- ☐ Understand why the company believes you are ready.
- ☐ Make sure you have the support needed to succeed.
- ☐ Use competing offers or strong references carefully if negotiating.
- ☐ Be prepared to meet higher expectations from day one.

6. Onboarding to a new job

- ☐ Celebrate the offer, then prepare seriously for onboarding.
- ☐ Ask your future manager how to prepare before starting.
- ☐ Clarify goals for the first month, first 3 months, and first 6 months.
- ☐ Keep a work log or brag document from the beginning.
- ☐ Keep a weekly journal of what you learned and what is unclear.
- ☐ Learn how performance reviews and promotions work.
- ☐ Find an onboarding buddy or trusted peer.
- ☐ Create a cheat sheet for acronyms, systems, commands, people, and resources.
- ☐ Learn the tech stack and team priorities.
- ☐ Meet key teammates and stakeholders early.

- ☐ For senior+ roles, clarify current and future projects, priorities, and business context.
- ☐ For staff+ roles, meet peer staff engineers, understand expectations, and spend time with product and cross-functional partners.